

Chapter 8

China's Role and Contributions



After its return to the global stage following Nixon's historic visit and the restoration of relations with Western nations, as well as its return to the United Nations, the role of the People's Republic of China has been evolving and changing as the country grows and develops. Its increased economic influence and status as the largest trading partner of many nations has given it increased political and diplomatic influence, which has enabled it to contribute considerably to resolving global conflict and maintaining global peace.

Particularly in recent years, as significant global conflicts have arisen in Ukraine and the Middle East, China has been working to broker peace and promote stability in regions where conflict is damaging trade, economic development, and the overall welfare of the people of those regions. Following its "Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence," China has continually called for conflict parties and major global players to sit down and work together to establish a diplomatic solution.

However, China's relatively neutral stance and even perceived cooperation with certain parties vis-à-vis the West, as well as criticisms that its peace proposals are unactionable, have made it difficult for China to make headway and take the lead in peace talks in conflicts like Ukraine and the Gaza Strip. That said, despite its soft-touch approach of engagement with all parties and its reluctance to take sides, or rather because of it, China enjoys the trust and maintains channels of communication that countries like the United States and EU members states lack, which could be extremely consequential in brokering true peace with countries like Russia.

Bridging this gap is possibly China's greatest advantage in conflict resolution and one that could make the difference in negotiations for a real, lasting peace that is based on mutual respect and shared interest. In this chapter, we will focus on China's evolving role and the work it has done to foster peace and stability in some of the world's most conflict-prone regions. This focus will be mainly on the Middle East and the Russia-Ukraine war but also provides a mirror for other global conflicts and alternative options for resolution.

Becoming a True Global Player

China's historical impact on the world stage, both regional and global, is undeniable. From a cultural powerhouse that has influenced not only its Asian neighbors, but also the palaces and homes of Europe and America, to its economic and political prowess, which in recent years has weighed increasingly heavy on global relations, China is becoming a true global player.

As a member of the United Nations Security Council, China's role in maintaining global peace and security is enshrined at the core of the very institutions that are charged with preventing and resolving conflict. During the early days of its membership, its status as a developing country and relatively weak military meant that it was unable to fully participate in global peacekeeping efforts, but in recent years, China has stepped up to take a more active role.

China's position that its increased involvement in international affairs and action taken on global issues is not a threat to the status quo or any other nation, but it has, nonetheless, concern among traditional powers, which see the outcome as a zero-sum situation in which if China gains, they lose. China's non-traditional approach has been welcomed by much of the developing world, which is also often used as a synonym for the Global South, which increasingly views China as a preferable partner in brokering peace in times of conflict. It is for this reason that China is increasingly seen as a stabilizing force in geopolitics.

The first article in this chapter, "China Is Ready to Be an Anchor in a Brave New Multipolar World," China's position as a staunch and effective supporter of multilateralism and equality for marginalized nations is important in reaching the developing world. The next article in this chapter, "China as a Global Player in the International Arena: A Growing Role on the International Stage," builds on this theme by taking a close look at China's approach to international diplomacy, including its efforts to mediate conflicts, but also how it engages the world through BRICS and broader economic collaboration, opting for alternative avenues to peace that differentiate it from traditional Western approaches.

China's Role as a Mediator for Peace

The role of mediator is one to which China is uniquely suited. Having risen from a developing country to the verge of a middle-income country, China still remains rooted in the Global South, from its relations with ASEAN and Central Asian nations to African countries, which is epitomized in its Belt and Road Initiative. The goodwill and economic relations it has built with these countries is something that the developed world cannot match.

However, China, the economic powerhouse, has made it indispensable to developed countries as well, which relies on China for a large part of their manufacturing and as a key market for the products that they consume. This economic link means that China has the leverage and the channels to work both within the developed world as well as the developing world.

As China becomes a more proactive member of peacekeeping missions and works with other nations to prevent and resolve conflicts, it has gained a reputation for being more flexible and open to alternative ways of mediating those conflicts. The third

article in this chapter, titled “Why China Is Becoming a Top Choice for Mediation in Global Conflicts,” examines how China is reaching across regional and economic gaps to create consensus among BRICS member nations, Middle Eastern countries as well as Russia, making a transformative force for peace.

The fourth article in this chapter, “China Can Play a Greater Role in Mediating Major International Conflicts,” makes the case that China can and should leverage its advantages to actively participate in the mediation of conflicts and foster peaceful resolutions, providing nine points on how China can contribute constructively to this process. This is also echoed in the fifth article in this chapter, “China Can Serve as a Catalyst in Global North-South Cooperation,” which examines how China's relationship specifically with the Global South places it in a unique position to bridge the gap that exists between the West and many non-Western or developing nations experiencing conflict.

Turning the focus to China's economic influence as an important factor that it can leverage in mediating conflict, the sixth article in this chapter, “China's Mediation Role and Economic Diplomacy: Fostering Peace and Progress in the Middle East,” takes a closer look at China's success in a region where Western diplomacy has traditionally had limited impact. Highlighting China's achievement in restoring relations between Saudi Arabia and Iran, it argues that the same techniques could be used to broker a lasting peace between Israel and Palestine.

China's Unique Approach to Brokering a Russia-Ukraine Peace

Perhaps the most contentious conflict in recent history with far-reaching implications for global order and global peace, the war between Russia and Ukraine is redefining how the world aligns itself. Russia's actions have created fear in Europe of a real threat of war, which has not been felt since the end of World War II, as evidenced by both Finland and Sweden choosing to join NATO.

It has also affected China, which, because of its willingness to maintain normal trade with Russia and not join sanctions on its biggest neighbor, has caused the West to say that it has allied itself with Russia, creating an ideological battle of autocracy vs. democracy.

However, China has continued to maintain its middle-of-the-road position, showing its opposition to Russia's actions by maintaining its support for sovereignty for all nations and calling for the immediate cessation of hostilities as part of a framework peace proposal. At the same time it continues to emphasize inclusive negotiations that bring together not only conflicting parties, but other major regional and global powers to discuss a solution together.

The next article in this chapter, titled “China Can Help Trump and Putin End the War in Ukraine,” highlights the latest developments in negotiations to bring peace to Ukraine, emphasizing the role of China and other BRICS countries as essential to the peace process and future rebuilding efforts. The eighth article in this chapter, titled “Why China Remains the World's Best Chance for Peace in Ukraine,” provides more background on this, highlighting that the difficulties the United States and Europe are facing in resolving the war in Ukraine, while also highlighting the fact that China's unique position on the global stage, including its relations with Russia, could make

it the most effective in achieving a lasting peace. This theme is revisited again in the next article, titled “Why China Is Best Placed to Help Negotiate an End to the Ukraine War,” starts by highlighting the inroads made with Russia and other nations through the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, which demonstrates the importance of keeping the channels of communication open with all parties and exploring all options, which China, along with Türkiye, been successful in accomplish and may very well make them best placed to negotiate a lasting peace in Ukraine.

With more understanding of Russia's position than most, at the very start of the war, China saw that Russia was in an awkward position from which it could not easily extricate itself. The tenth article in this chapter, “It's Time to Offer Russia an Offramp, China Can Help with That,” highlights China's approach to compromise at a very early stage in the war when Western nations were focused on hitting Russia with painful sanctions to frustrate its war efforts, to find a multilateral solution.

However, far from unequivocally supporting Russia, China has clearly voiced its opposition and continually called for a peaceful diplomatic solution to hostilities, putting forward its own peace plan. The next article in this chapter, “As Ukraine War Drags On, Why Not Give China's Peace Plan a Chance?,” reiterates China's efforts in pushing for peace. Despite Western criticisms that the plan has no actionable solutions, it remains the best foundation for ending hostilities and bringing everyone together to discuss the road toward peace.

The final article in this chapter, titled “Alarm over a ‘China-Russia Axis’ Revives Unwanted Cold War Mentality,” warns against jumping to conclusions over a perceived alliance between China and Russia. The return to a simplistic bipolar Cold War narrative in today's clearly multipolar world is unrealistic and impractical. China is not in an alliance with Russia, and attempts to push this narrative could have the unintended result of pushing the two countries closer together.

As a great power, China has historically contributed positively to regional peace and global prosperity. Despite the relatively recent contributions by the West to global institutions and practices, as well as the real contributions made to global peace and prosperity, especially post-World War II, it is important that China reclaim its traditional role to ensure a balance in global decision-making and ensure that it can once again be a part of and contribute to global governance.

China Is Ready to Be an Anchor in a Brave New Multipolar World¹

What seems clear from this year's MSC is that an evolution towards a pluralistic world order is coming. We need an effective governance framework to embrace this new multipolar world by reforming institutions and involving more nations in the conversation.

The title of the latest Munich Security Report says it all. After 2022's "Turning the Tide—Unlearning Helplessness," 2023's "Re: vision" and last year's "Lose-Lose?," this year's tome, released ahead of the Munich Security Conference last month, is called "Multipolarisation" The unipolar era has ended.

I was the sole Chinese speaker invited to the conference's kick-off event and attended the report's release. Having taken part in the Munich Security Conference's side events for years, I reckon far more delegates this year were from the Global South, a reflection of rising multipolarity.

As US President Donald Trump's agenda takes shape, many attendees seem to view China as a stabilizing counterweight—a role China appears poised to embrace.

The conference's thematic arc mirrors a broader reckoning. Three years ago, the debate over "collective helplessness" captured the disarray in the transatlantic sphere. Last year's exploration of "lose-lose dynamics" framed the tensions of zero-sum competition. This year's focus on multipolarization reflects a world of dispersing powers—a transition turbocharged by Trump 2.0.

Trump's tariff threats and deal-making instincts dominated Munich's corridors, casting a shadow over discussions as attendees grappled with the implications of his aggressive trade agenda.

Amid this, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi's call for multilateralism resonated deeply, offering a counterpoint that emphasized cooperation over confrontation in a shifting geopolitical landscape. His vision of an "equal and orderly multipolar world" struck a chord with those seeking stability, while his critique of protectionism underscored China's contrasting approach to global ties.

China's actions—slashing tariffs to zero for over 40 least developed nations last year, after waiving duties on 98% of products from over 20 African countries—are a rebuttal to protectionism. These initiatives have yielded results, with Chinese imports from Africa increasing by 14% year on year to US\$60.15 billion in the first half of last year, according to China customs.

Such economic diplomacy has earned China accolades as a stabilizing force in an uncertain world. Meanwhile, the Russia-Ukraine war has highlighted China's potential as a peacemaker.

Trump's plan, which bars Ukraine from joining NATO and relies on European forces to keep the peace, faces widespread skepticism. With Russian President Vladimir Putin likely to resist a Western-led peace corps, the Trump administration has shifted the dynamics: no US troops, relying instead on contributions from Europe and potentially elsewhere.

¹ First published on March 4, 2025 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

Here, China could take a leading role. Having contributed more UN peacekeepers in recent years than any other permanent UN Security Council member, China could spearhead a neutral force, possibly alongside India and Brazil.

Beijing's diplomatic clout is growing, as seen in Iran-Saudi Arabia rapprochement and Myanmar ceasefires. A UN-led effort could give Putin an exit, stabilizing Eastern Europe and advancing a multipolar conflict resolution.

Economic tensions took center stage at the Munich debates. In a closed-door session on economic security, I suggested countering Trump's tariff hikes with reductions, mirroring the spirit of China's visa-free entry policy for 54 nations, including the United States.

One representative—not from China—sparked enthusiastic commentary by proposing a unified response: cutting tariffs as Trump raises them, maintaining open markets and reinforcing frameworks like the Paris Agreement and the World Trade Organization to offset his policies. Such a strategy could dull the impact of protectionism, showcasing China's resilience and reinforcing Beijing's role as a pillar of multilateralism.

Trump's deal-driven approach strains Western unity. In his conference speech, US Vice President JD Vance targeted Europe's vulnerabilities—restrictions on free speech, secular shifts—framing them, I believe, as leverage for trade negotiations. Reports of Trump's phone call with Putin suggesting a thaw have further unsettled transatlantic confidence.

Departing from past military-centric agendas, Trump's focus on economic wins over ideology signals a profound shift. At the conference, I suggested this could usher in a "grand triangle" era, with US-China-Europe ties shaped by practical agreements rather than dogma.

The world is evolving into a pluralistic order with China, the United States, and Europe as three interconnected pillars. Take the recent Paris AI Action Summit: China, France, Germany, indeed the entire European Union and dozens of countries forged a pact while the United States and Britain stood apart.

Yet this multipolarity still lacks effective governance. The Munich Security Conference's inclusivity, with growing voices from the Global South and women, marks progress, but global frameworks are lagging behind. The UN Security Council, WTO, and the Paris Agreement remain tilted toward Western interests, often marginalizing emerging powers.

China's diplomatic track record provides a potential model: its advocacy in expanding BRICS to offer membership to the likes of Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates amplifies the Global South's voice. These nations crave a bigger role in global systems—perhaps via a reformed UN Security Council with permanent African and Latin American seats, or a trade pact to rival the WTO's faltering reach.

Trump's deal-making era challenges this emerging order. His economic focus—reflected in picks like Ambassador to China David Perdue, a former Fortune 500 CEO, and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, a Wall Street veteran—might splinter alliances or spark new ones. China's response—blending peacekeeping with openness—positions it uniquely.

China's extension of visa-free access to countries such as the United States and Canada, as I suggested at the conference, could amplify its soft power, while joint Belt and Road Initiative-EU Global Gateway projects in Africa could model cooperation across poles.

Munich made it clear: the multipolar world has arrived. Given this shift, with its diplomatic finesse and multilateral commitment, China can guide the new world toward peace and stability.

China as a Global Player in the International Arena: A Growing Role on the International Stage²

From diplomatic breakthroughs in the Middle East and brokering peace between Russia and Ukraine to calming economic waves with Europe, China's increasingly important and consequential role on the global stage is undeniable.

As the global economy and politics undergo significant shifts, China, as one of the largest beneficiaries of the global system, seeks to strengthen and enhance the global governance with all major powers. We have entered into a multipolar world and China has risen as a key player, utilizing its economic power and diplomatic skill to contribute and improve the international multilateral system. With conflicts simmering worldwide, China's role as a mediator in wars and disputes has increasingly come to the fore. This influence stems not only from its economic strength but also from its sophisticated approach to diplomacy, anchored in principles of peaceful coexistence and mutual respect. Furthermore, China has implemented innovative strategies for economic development and green transition, while also advocating for multilateral cooperation and strengthening its engagement with the Global South. These efforts are poised to profoundly redefine the contours of international relations in the evolving world order.

China's Emerging Role in Mediation of Wars and Conflicts

As global conflicts simmer, China's role as a mediator is gaining prominence, with its economic influence and diplomatic connections helping it to foster dialogue.

Last month, Ukrainian Foreign Minister Dmytro Kuleba met his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi in Guangzhou. During their talks, Wang reiterated China's commitment to promoting a political resolution to the Russian war on Ukraine, a stance that received a positive response from Kuleba. China's significant influence largely stems from its economic connections with the parties to the conflict. During the Guangzhou talks, Wang emphasized China's role as Ukraine's largest trading partner.

According to the Chinese customs office, bilateral trade was at \$6.81 billion last year. Wang also pointed out China's position as the primary importer of Ukrainian agricultural products and underscored Ukraine's early participation in the Belt and Road Initiative.

At the same time, China's position as Russia's top trading partner, with bilateral trade rising to US\$240.1 billion last year, further solidifies its unique role as a potential neutral mediator. This economic interdependence with both nations gives China leverage that few other countries can match.

China's economic diplomacy scored a notable success a year ago when it brokered the restoration of ties between long-standing rivals Iran and Saudi Arabia. As a major

² First published on September 2, 2024 by *Bled Strategic Times* and revised for this collection.

trading partner and the largest oil customer of both nations, China wielded significant influence. This economic leverage was bolstered by major bilateral agreements: a 25-year cooperation deal with Iran reached in 2021 and a strengthening of its comprehensive strategic partnership with Saudi Arabia in 2022.

China's deep economic ties with these Middle Eastern powers provided both the means and the motivation to push for their reconciliation. As Israel's third-largest trading partner, and with bilateral trade volume reaching US\$14.5 billion last year, China can also play a significant role in promoting a peaceful resolution to the Gaza crisis, potentially offering a path to dialogue where traditional diplomacy has faltered.

Furthermore, China's seat on the UN Security Council has become a cornerstone of its growing diplomatic influence, particularly in its push for multilateral solutions to global conflicts. After the conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza broke out, China proposed high-level international conferences to address the crises. This approach bore fruit earlier this year when rival Palestinian factions came together for the Beijing Declaration, a rare moment of unity brokered through Chinese diplomacy. Days later, on July 25, China's Permanent Representative to the UN Fu Cong reiterated Beijing's stance on the war in Ukraine during a Security Council review, emphasizing the need for peace talks and a political resolution.

More importantly, China's approach to international diplomacy is deeply rooted in its historical narrative and foreign policy principles. China doesn't have a colonial past and has not engaged in invasive military campaigns in recent history, which serves as a foundation for its credibility on the global stage. This stance, encapsulated in its "Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence," emphasizes dialogue and consultation over force and aggression in resolving international disputes.

In addition, China's diplomatic efforts extend to developing nations, as evidenced by the recent China-Brazil consensus on the Ukraine crisis. Their six-point proposal outlines key de-escalation principles, including no expansion of the battlefield, no escalation of fighting, and no provocation by any party. Significantly, it proposes an international peace conference to be held at a time agreeable to both Russia and Ukraine, ensuring equal participation and fair discussion of all peace plans. This trend was also underscored last year when an African peace delegation visited Ukraine and Russia.

China Can Promote Global Economic Collaboration and Green Transition

On July 4, 2024, the European Commission announced anti-subsidy duties ranging from 17.4% to 37.6% on Chinese EVs. The EU's decision to impose additional taxes on Chinese new energy vehicles is unnecessary. At a time when the global climate is experiencing record-breaking changes, we should be more committed to adhering to the Paris Agreement. The International Energy Agency (IEA) projects that global demand for new photovoltaic installations will reach 820 gigawatts, roughly four

times the capacity added in 2022. This surge in demand is driven by the need to meet the ambitious targets set by the Paris Agreement. The green appetite of the world market is huge and dwarfs the capacity of suppliers. To achieve climate goals outlined in the Paris Agreement, substantial investments in clean energy are imperative—\$4 trillion in annual investments are required according to the IEA, with only \$1.7 trillion having been fulfilled in 2023. The gap between required investment and actual expenditure underscores the need for high-cost-effective products, advanced technologies, and efficient resource allocation. It is impossible for China to handle the challenge of climate alone.

China has made significant progress in enhancing its capacity to produce renewable energy technologies. In 2023, China manufactured 90% of the world's solar panels, cementing its position as a global leader in this sector. Moreover, China has emerged as a dominant force in the electric vehicle market, accounting for 60% of global EV sales.

Therefore, China and Europe should promptly resume the China-EU Comprehensive Agreement on Investment, lifting sanctions previously imposed on each other. Further the removing EU Parliament should encourage Chinese companies to invest in Europe, thereby boosting local employment, increasing tax revenue, revitalizing the manufacturing sector, and removing tariffs. Decoupling between China and Europe is not an option.

China and Europe should also vigorously develop cooperation on the digital economy and AI.

I have recently co-hosted with H.E. Patricia Flor, German Ambassador to China and H.E. Bertrand Lortholary, French Ambassador to China, a symposium at the CCG titled "European and Chinese Perspectives on AI Governance" to outline the importance of AI cooperation between the EU and China. Moreover, the importance of the digital economy and its governance cannot be emphasized enough. According to the China Academy of Information and Communications Technology (CAICT), the digital economy now accounts for nearly 60% of global GDP. In China, the digital economy has shown remarkable growth, consistently outpacing overall GDP growth for 11 consecutive years. As the latest data suggests, the digital economy contributes 41.5% to China's GDP, a figure that highlights its increasing significance, rivaling the contribution of the secondary industry to the national economy, which presents enormous opportunities for European companies to work in China and jointly in third countries.

China Can Deepen Global Cooperation with the Global South

China is steadily carving out its role as a responsible major power on the global stage, with a firm commitment to actively engage with a wide range of international bodies, including the United Nations, BRICS, G7, and G20. This engagement underscores China's dedication to global governance and its proactive stance on addressing the pressing challenges facing the world today. Among its core priorities is the advocacy

for global peace and stability, with a particular emphasis on the critical need to prevent the escalation of nuclear conflict.

In pursuit of these goals, China has expressed a strong willingness to collaborate with key global players, notably Europe and the United States, to tackle a host of global issues that require collective action. One of the areas where China's diplomatic influence could be particularly impactful is in the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war. By taking an active role in mediating this crisis, China has the potential to contribute significantly to de-escalating tensions and finding a peaceful resolution. Simultaneously, Europe's involvement could serve as a catalyst in advancing China-US relations, fostering a more constructive dialogue and cooperation between these two major powers. Through such multilateral efforts, China demonstrates its commitment to a balanced and pragmatic approach to international relations, aiming to build bridges and reinforce global stability in an increasingly complex world.

China has been collaborating with members of the Global South to bridge the gap between developing and developed countries. China, as a founding member of BRICS, has engaged heavily with developing countries in commerce and trade through BRICS. This BRICS mechanism is an increasingly influential force in the global financial sector and political security. Measured by purchasing power parity, the BRICS countries have already outpaced the G7, accounting for 35.6% of the world's GDP compared to the G7's 30.3%. By 2028, this disparity is projected to grow even more in favor of the BRICS, with estimates showing a ratio of 36.6% to 27.8%. The robust intra-BRICS economic cooperation has attracted more "middle power" nations to join. For example, in June, Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan discussed his country's pursuit of new opportunities to cooperate with BRICS in a speech at the Center for China and Globalization.

Conclusion

In conclusion, China's evolving role as a mediator in global conflicts underscores its growing influence on the international stage. By leveraging its economic ties and diplomatic principles, China has positioned itself as a key player in fostering dialogue and promoting political resolutions, as seen in its involvement in the Ukraine-Russia war and its successful mediation between Iran and Saudi Arabia. China's commitment to peaceful coexistence, coupled with its innovative approaches to economic development and green transition, further solidifies its leadership in shaping a new world order. As China advocates for multilateral cooperation and continues to deepen its engagement with the Global South, its efforts will likely play a pivotal role in redefining the contours of international relations in the years to come.

Why China Is Becoming a Top Choice for Mediation in Global Conflicts³

Specifically regarding the Ukraine-Russia war, China's economic influence, diplomatic connections and commitment to multilateral solutions makes it a potentially transformative force for peace.

As global conflicts simmer, China's role as a mediator is gaining prominence, with its economic influence, and diplomatic connections helping it to foster dialogue. Last month, Ukrainian Foreign Minister Dmytro Kuleba met with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi in Guangzhou. During their talks, Wang reiterated China's commitment to promoting a political resolution to the Russian war on Ukraine, a stance that received a positive response from Kuleba.

China's significant influence largely stems from its economic connections with the conflicting parties. During the Guangzhou talks, Wang emphasized China's role as Ukraine's largest trading partner. According to Chinese Customs, bilateral trade was at US\$6.81 billion last year. Wang also pointed out China's position as the primary importer of Ukrainian agricultural products and underscored Ukraine's early participation in the Belt and Road Initiative.

For his part, Kuleba acknowledged the importance of the bilateral relationship, calling the two not just trade partners, but also important economic and strategic partners. As the war in Ukraine grinds on, Kyiv appears to see Beijing's influence as increasingly vital. China, with its infrastructure expertise, could play a significant role in Ukraine's post-war reconstruction.

At the same time, China's position as Russia's top trading partner, with bilateral trade rising to US\$240.1 billion last year, further solidifies its unique role as a potential neutral mediator. This economic interdependence with both nations gives China leverage that few other countries can match.

China's economic diplomacy scored a notable success a year ago when it brokered the restoration of ties between long-standing rivals Iran and Saudi Arabia. As a major trading partner and the largest oil customer of both nations, China wielded significant influence. This economic leverage was bolstered by major bilateral agreements: a 25-year cooperation deal with Iran reached in 2021 and a strengthening of its comprehensive strategic partnership with Saudi Arabia in 2022.

China's deep economic ties with these Middle Eastern powers provided both the means and the motivation to push for their reconciliation. As Israel's third-largest trading partner, and with bilateral trade volume reaching US\$14.5 billion last year, China can also—I have reason to believe—play a significant role in promoting a peaceful resolution to the Gaza crisis, potentially offering a path to dialogue where traditional diplomacy has faltered.

Furthermore, China's seat on the UN Security Council has become a cornerstone of its growing diplomatic influence, particularly in its push for multilateral solutions

³ First published on August 16, 2024 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

to global conflicts. After the war in Ukraine and the conflict in Gaza broke out, Wang proposed high-level international conferences to address the crises.

This approach bore fruit earlier this year when rival Palestinian factions came together for the Beijing Declaration, a rare moment of unity brokered through Chinese diplomacy. Days later, on July 25, China's Permanent Representative to the UN Fu Cong reiterated Beijing's stance on the Ukraine war during a Security Council review, emphasizing the need for peace talks and a political resolution.

Over the past three decades, China has grown to become a major contributor of troops in UN peacekeeping operations, providing more peacekeepers than all the other UN Security Council permanent members combined, and is the second-largest financial backer of these operations. These commitments have helped to reshape China's international image, portraying it as a nation dedicated to global peace and a respect for sovereignty, which is markedly different from its once isolationist stance.

More importantly, China's approach to international diplomacy is deeply rooted in its historical narrative and foreign policy principles. China doesn't have a colonial past and has not engaged in invasive military campaigns in recent history, which serves as a foundation for its credibility on the global stage. This stance, encapsulated in its "Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence," emphasizes dialogue and consultation over force and aggression in resolving international disputes.

China's policy of non-interference in other countries' internal affairs, offering an alternative to interventionist approaches, has gained significant support, particularly among developing nations. As China's global interests expand alongside its economic and military capabilities, it continues to advocate for peaceful coexistence and non-intervention. Free from Cold War-era alliance constraints, China positions itself as a neutral mediator in global affairs—a role it increasingly embraces in today's complex geopolitical landscape.

In addition, China's diplomatic efforts extend to developing nations, as evidenced by the recent China-Brazil consensus on the Ukraine crisis. Their six-point proposal outlines key de-escalation principles, including no expansion of the battlefield, no escalation of fighting, and no provocation by any party. Significantly, it proposes an international peace conference, to be held at a time agreeable to both Russia and Ukraine, ensuring equal participation and fair discussion of all peace plans.

This trend was also underscored last year when an African peace delegation visited Ukraine and Russia. As a member of the BRICS bloc (original members include Brazil, Russia, India, and China), China encourages developing countries to join in fostering peaceful development frameworks.

Through sharing information, financial aid, project collaboration, and participation in international negotiations, Beijing of the Global South is strengthening its ties with the Global South, amplifying the collective voice of the Global South in global peace initiatives.

In conclusion, China's emerging role in global conflict resolution leverages its economic influence and diplomatic reach to unite diverse stakeholders. By creating dialogue platforms that bridge long-standing divides, Beijing offers a fresh approach to peace negotiations.

China's commitment to multilateral solutions and engagement with all parties positions it as a potentially transformative force in international peacekeeping. This approach not only advances China's diplomatic interests but also reflects its vision of a shared future for humanity, potentially reshaping the landscape of global conflict resolution in the years to come.

China Can Play a Greater Role in Mediating Major International Conflicts⁴

Stalemates in global conflicts such as Ukraine and Gaza are evidence that traditional powers are having difficulty quelling tensions, but China shows promise as a new mediator in international conflict areas.

In the turbulent landscape of global affairs, conflicts such as the ongoing Russia-Ukraine crisis and the perennial strife between Israel and Palestine serve as stark reminders of the human cost and geopolitical repercussions of unresolved disputes. As the world reflects on the devastating toll of these conflicts, it is increasingly evident that concerted efforts toward peace and stability are imperative. In this context, as a major power, China has emerged as an advocate for peaceful resolutions to international conflicts, actively engaging in diplomatic efforts that promote global harmony.

The Russia-Ukraine war is now entering its third year and has left a trail of devastation on both sides. Ukrainian President Zelenskyy's announcement that 31,000 Ukrainian soldiers have been killed underscores the grim reality of the war's human toll.

According to the United Nations Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine, over 10,000 civilians, including hundreds of children, have perished, with thousands more suffering injuries. Similarly, significant casualties have been reported among Russian forces, with hundreds of thousands either killed or wounded.

Meanwhile, the ongoing strife between Israel and Palestine continues to exact a heavy toll on civilian lives, particularly in the besieged enclave of Gaza. With over 22,000 fatalities and tens of thousands injured, the conflict has inflicted immeasurable suffering on the population, representing a significant loss of life in proportion to Gaza's pre-war population.

In the midst of these crises, China has positioned itself as a proactive advocate for peace and stability on the international stage. Foreign Minister Wang Yi's address at the 60th Munich Security Conference underscored China's commitment to serve as a stabilizing force in global affairs. China's proactive engagement is evidenced by its multifaceted diplomatic initiatives, including its twelve-point peace proposal for the Russia-Ukraine war and its instrumental role in facilitating the restoration of diplomatic relations between Saudi Arabia and Iran. Moreover, China has consistently championed constructive and responsible actions by influential nations, particularly in safeguarding critical maritime routes such as Red Sea shipping lanes.

Despite these efforts, these and other conflicts continue to destabilize the international order. It is imperative that we consider truly actionable recommendations aimed at mitigating tensions and fostering peaceful resolutions. The following are immediate, practical actions that we believe would have a real impact on resolving existing conflicts and promoting peace:

⁴ First published on April 30, 2024 by *Global Solutions Journal*: Issue 10 and revised for this collection.

The first of these is a Peace Conference for Ukraine. As a third party not directly or indirectly involved in the Ukraine war, China has remained objective and impartial on the issue of Ukraine, advocating for peace and dialogue. President Xi Jinping has personally had in-depth conversations with leaders from multiple countries including, Russia and Ukraine. China has proposed a twelve-point peace plan, emphasizing the importance of respecting national sovereignty and territorial integrity, and upholding the United Nations Charter. China has stated that a nuclear war cannot be waged in Ukraine and that nuclear facilities should not be bombed. All these efforts have been aimed at paving the way for a ceasefire and dialogue.

We believe that a comprehensive peace conference should be convened, inviting all relevant stakeholders, including Russia, and welcoming mediation efforts from countries such as Türkiye and Switzerland. In previous meetings, Russia has not been invited to participate as Ukraine insists on the complete withdrawal of all Russian troops from its territory, the restoration of borders to their pre-1991 Soviet era configuration, and the establishment of mechanisms to hold Moscow accountable. However, genuine peace talks cannot occur without Russia's involvement.

The 10th China and Globalization Forum, organized by CCG, offered a timely and flexible platform that was conducive to analyzing the complexities surrounding the Ukraine issue. Its focus on fostering dialogue and exploring global issues gave policymakers, academics, and experts from around the world a unique opportunity to come together and engage in constructive discussions regarding the various aspects of the situation in Ukraine. The insightful analysis, exchange of perspectives, and exploration of potential solutions that came out of the discussions during the forum could ultimately pave the way for informed and collaborative efforts toward peace and stability in the region.

Second, a High-Level International Conference for Israel and Palestine should be convened. Currently, Israel has ignored warnings and condemnations from the international community, not only refusing to exchange hostages with Hamas but also reiterating its threats to attack the southern Gaza city of Rafah. Humanitarian supplies provided by the international community to the Gaza Strip need to enter through the Rafah crossing connected to Egypt. If the area falls victim to airstrikes and ground attacks or ultimately comes under the control of the Israeli military, it will be extremely difficult for international humanitarian aid to reach the hands of civilians in Gaza. Even the United States has expressed opposition to the current situation, with the US State Department announcing sanctions against three individuals and two entities in Israel. While these sanctions may seem mild, they represent the first public condemnation by the United States of Israel's violence toward Palestinians.

China hopes to find a comprehensive, equitable, and lasting solution to the Palestinian issue. More immediately, it hopes to facilitate an immediate ceasefire to prevent further escalation or loss of control. It opposes actions that harm civilians or violate international law and calls for the protection of civilians and humanitarian assistance to prevent an even more severe humanitarian disaster. China supports the prompt convening of a more authoritative, extensive, and effective international conference to promote the resumption of Israeli-Palestinian talks, including the development of a specific timetable and roadmap. China insists that the United Nations should

take the lead in organizing high-level talks involving the permanent members of the Security Council, alongside Palestinian and Israeli representatives. China's proactive stance on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict has been exemplified by its presidency of the Security Council last November, which culminated in the passage of Resolution 2712 and underscores its potential to advance peace efforts in the region.

Third, China can serve as a guarantor of a Russia-Ukraine ceasefire. On June 17, 2023, during a meeting with a delegation from Africa in Saint Petersburg, Russian President Putin presented a draft of the Istanbul Agreement, which was outlined in March 2022 in Istanbul, aimed at resolving the Ukraine issue. The draft designated China, the United States, the United Kingdom, Türkiye, France, and Belarus as "guarantor countries" of the agreement. Given its amicable relations and strategic partnerships with both Russia and Ukraine, China is well-positioned to serve as a guarantor of a ceasefire agreement, thereby facilitating diplomatic negotiations and peace-building efforts.

Fourth, UN Peacekeeping Forces should be rapidly deployed to Ukraine and Palestine, ensuring that peacekeeping operations adhere to international law and norms, having obtained proper authorization and clear mandates. The deployment and activities of peacekeeping forces must be decided by the United Nations Security Council or General Assembly and require the consent of relevant parties. A key benefit of this is that UN peacekeeping actions can only proceed after the consent of all parties involved in the conflict, to prevent UN peacekeeping forces from becoming a new party to the conflict. China's continued commitment to UN peacekeeping operations positions it as a valuable contributor to efforts aimed at maintaining peace and stability in conflict-affected regions.

Fifth, China can support reconstruction efforts in Ukraine and Gaza. Having endured the ravages of war and suffering immense destruction, Ukraine will be in urgent need of reconstruction. Leveraging its expertise as a major infrastructure builder, China can play a pivotal role in post-conflict reconstruction efforts, thereby fostering socio-economic development and stability in the conflict-affected areas. Ukraine could facilitate this by ending sanctions on the China Railway Construction Corporation (CRCC), which were implemented because of the company's cooperation with Russia. It should also retract its statements that it would "not use Chinese high-speed rail" technology post-war. It should instead welcome Chinese infrastructure companies to participate in the reconstruction of Ukraine. In the Gaza Strip, China has provided emergency humanitarian aid such as food and medicine, and has announced it will provide hundreds of millions of dollars in aid to the Gaza Strip for the purpose of rebuilding infrastructure and providing relief. This funding will help restore the normal economic order of the Gaza Strip and improve the living conditions of its people.

Sixth is the implementation of a Two-State Solution for Israel-Palestine. Looking ahead, a two-state solution remains the most viable path forward for the region. The ongoing status quo and long-standing history of conflict in the region since 1947 means that the primary challenge lies in facilitating and implementing a feasible resolution. This should manifest itself in the creation of a Palestinian state that can foster harmonious coexistence between Israel and Arab nations. China, ranked as the

third-most-favored mediator among Palestinians according to an Arab News YouGov poll, behind Russia and the EU, has the potential to play a core role in this process.

Seventh, the international community should support Ukraine's accession to the EU without NATO membership. If Ukraine successfully joins the European Union, it will benefit from the free movement of goods within the EU market, freedom of investment, and more convenient trade conditions. This would bring about more economic development opportunities for Ukraine and enhance the country's economic standing. However, joining NATO would provoke continued strong opposition from Russia, which sees NATO membership as a challenge to Russia's security interests and could lead to increased tension between the two countries.

Eighth, cooperation among major powers and middle powers should be enhanced. In the pursuit of global peace and stability, collaboration among major powers such as China, the United States, and Europe, alongside middle powers like Türkiye, Japan, South Korea, Australia, and BRICS nations, is essential. By leveraging multilateral platforms such as the United Nations, these countries can collectively address major international conflicts through dialogue and diplomacy. China is in a unique position to engage extensively with all parties, promoting openness and inclusivity over isolation and exclusivity, as well as negotiation and cooperation over confrontation and antagonism. China could proactively lead a call for multilateralism and the exploration of win-win outcomes while working to prevent scenarios that result in losses for individual countries and the international community.

Last but not least, as frictions in commerce and technology mount between major powers, especially manifested in export controls, sanctions, punitive tariffs, and investment restrictions, China, the United States, and the EU have a growing interest in preventing the situation from getting out of control. Further, spillovers from these challenges pose a growing threat to the supply chain and end users in Global South as well. It would be feasible to put in a guardrail mechanism for telecom equipment vendors, social media giants, and AI companies in front a gathering of various authorities, to have sensitivities and controversies laid out and tackled.

In conclusion, in finding solutions to the daunting challenges posed by ongoing conflicts, we feel that China's proactive approach to peacemaking offers a beacon of hope for global peace and stability. By leveraging its diplomatic influence, fostering dialogue among conflicting parties, and advocating for constructive engagement, China can play a pivotal role in easing tensions and fostering lasting peace in regions marred by strife and suffering. As the world grapples with the consequences of conflict, concerted efforts toward peacemaking and mediation are imperative, and China stands ready to contribute to these noble endeavors.

China Can Serve as a Catalyst in Global North-South Cooperation⁵

As the world continues to lean into regionalism and derisking, the Global South could serve as a new source of partners. In this context, China could help to facilitate North-South trade and exchange.

2023 was dubbed the “Year of the Global South” in some media, with *Foreign Policy* publishing that the rise in political influence of countries in the Global South was a pivotal trend to watch in 2023.

Initially coined in Carl Oglesby’s 1969 anti-colonial piece, the term “Global South” received official endorsement in the 2004 “Forging a Global South” initiative by the United Nations Development Programme.

During the Cold War, the term “Global South” often designated the Third World countries which remained non-aligned with either the United States or the Soviet Union. After the Cold War, the term evolved into “developing countries,” a term now prevalent in contemporary national and UN discourse.

However, “Global South” today is a term more frequently encountered in less formal contexts and seldom features in official records or documents. In general, the Global South is characterized by three main attributes: a non-Western perspective, an anti-interventionist stance, and a focus on development.

As the global power dynamics undergo substantial adjustments with a reconfiguration of power structures, the Global South has demonstrated considerable flexibility and independence, which has objectively increased its influence and contributed to a more balanced distribution of power.

Surging Influence of Global South

Since the 2008 financial crisis, the rising GDP proportion of developing nations has to some extent laid a foundation for the Global South’s burgeoning clout. Developing G20 member states saw their collective GDP leap from 18.28% in 2008 to 30.52% in 2021, while the wider developing world contributed over half of global GDP.

Beyond economics, some non-Western countries leverage their geographic or resource advantages to reshape regional geopolitical dynamics. Türkiye exploits its pivotal location, OPEC countries wield their energy reserves and output, and Mexico benefits from its integral role in trade routes and supply chains. All are helping to recalibrate the political and economic landscape while maximizing their own interests. The Global South employs its comparative strengths to broaden its influence and yield tangible outcomes.

⁵ First published on January 22, 2024 by *People’s Daily* and revised for this collection. This article was co-authored by CCG Co-Founder and Secretary-General Mabel Lu Miao.

Following the onset of the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022, developing nations have asserted their independence through neutrality and advocated for negotiations while avoiding polarized stances. Amidst aggressive US monetary policy between 2022 and 2023 that rattled global finance, Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva's suggestion for BRICS nations to adopt local currencies for settlements aroused heated discussions in Western countries. BRICS today is an intergovernmental organization comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates. Meanwhile, BRICS' expansion in 2023 lent a heightened potency to the Global South in setting agendas and providing leadership.

China Link to Global South

Developed nations, acknowledging the Global South's ascending influence, are eager to collaborate on fronts including trade, climate change, infrastructure, and the digital economy. Strategies and objectives vary.

The United States has been seeking to woo developing nations and isolate China.

The European Union views the development of relations with the Global South as a part of its so-called "derisking" strategy. Facing more severe security, economic, and leadership challenges, the EU is more focused on forging a "third way" for its vision of a new global order through cooperation with developing countries.

As a developing nation, China aligns with the Global South through its membership in the Group of 77, its advocacy within the Non-Aligned Movement, and its natural synergies with this demographic. China's cooperation with the Global South is marked by inclusiveness and innovation as epitomized by the Belt and Road Initiative.

The post-Cold War period featured a long-established so-called "only superpower and multi-great power" global hierarchy. Recent years have seen unavoidable adjustments. The ascent of the Global South signals a pivot toward a new equilibrium in the global order, a transition that is far from simple. The sheer variety in politics, culture, and economies makes the Global South less risk-averse but susceptible to internal divergence.

China is the largest developing country in the world, and China can be an ideal bridge between the Global South and North. China, while prioritizing Global South interests, can judiciously mediate between the aspirations of developing and developed countries. By enhancing North-South cooperation and mitigating zero-sum scenarios, China can foster more enduring global development and improved world governance.

China's Mediation Role and Economic Diplomacy: Fostering Peace and Progress in the Middle East⁶

China's historical experience and non-colonial past create a resonance between it and Middle Eastern nations, which gives it a unique advantage in mediating peace and progress in that region.

China's position as the third-most-favored mediator among Palestinians, according to an Arab News YouGov poll, trailing Russia and the EU, comes as no surprise. This ranking aligns with the perception of Palestinians and resonates with China's fair stance and thoughtful contributions to peace in the Middle East. Notably, China played a pivotal role in brokering the Saudi-Iran rapprochement in March, underlining its commitment to fostering dialogue and reducing tensions in the region.

The thaw between Riyadh and Tehran highlights the importance of having a reliable and impartial mediator, rather than a major power flexing its muscles and overpowering smaller nations. It is evident that a mediator who operates in good faith, ensuring reliability and fairness, can inject new momentum into the process of easing hostility. China's contribution, after hard work by Oman and Iraq, was instrumental in facilitating the resumption of diplomatic relations between Saudi Arabia and Iran.

The Middle East rightfully belongs to the people of the region, and its future should be determined by them. Irrespective of the complexity and challenges involved, a mutually acceptable solution can only be achieved through equal-footed dialogue based on mutual respect.

It is no coincidence that both Saudi Arabia and Iran enjoy substantial trade links with China. China holds the position of being the top trading partner of both nations, and it stands as the largest buyer of their oil. Recent years have witnessed the strengthening of these relationships through significant agreements, including the signing of a 25-year cooperation deal with Iran in 2021 and a comprehensive strategic partnership agreement with Saudi Arabia in 2022. These developments position China with unique persuasive power and a strong incentive to advocate for detente.

The re-establishment of diplomatic ties between Saudi Arabia and Iran is set to exert influence on regional developments. The widespread welcome from almost all regional countries is indicative of their belief that these agreements will contribute to political stability and economic development. The Saudi-Iran deal can be seen as a continuation of the ongoing process of Middle Eastern normalization, which has gained momentum in various dimensions, including intra-Gulf/Arab efforts.

Many regional countries have been actively diversifying their foreign relations, seeking to improve ties with different regional and global powers. This strategic approach aims to break dependencies on specific global powers and enhance autonomy in decision-making.

From the perspective of the Chinese people, the turbulence in the Middle East, including the Palestine-Israel conflict, is seen as a legacy of the problematic geopolitical order established during the era of colonialism. The imperial powers partitioned

⁶ First published on June 6, 2023 by *Arab News* and revised for this collection.

the Middle East, reshaped political maps, and reduced the region to a provider of oil pipelines and gas stations—largely for just a few. The historical reality of the Middle East, reinforced by international power structures, continues to shape the challenges faced today.

China's approach to the Middle East is informed by its own history, marked by a period of humiliation in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. The lessons learned have guided China to avoid repeating such experiences and to refrain from imposing its will on others, particularly through force or coercion.

China unequivocally rejects the replication of failed interventionist approaches pursued by others. It instead seeks neutral engagement with all parties based on mutually beneficial agreements, coupled with empathy. China established formal diplomatic relations with Palestine in 1988, preceding its relations with Israel by four years. In 2013, China presented a four-point proposal emphasizing the importance of an independent Palestinian State, peaceful coexistence between Palestine and Israel, and the establishment of a sovereign Palestine based on the 1967 borders, with East Jerusalem as its capital—a right inherent to the Palestinian people.

The recent escalation of the Palestine-Israel conflict serves as a stark reminder of the pressing need to address the Palestinian question. The international community must prioritize this matter, placing it high on the international agenda. A steadfast commitment to the two-state solution, advocating for the early resumption of peace talks, and addressing the legitimate aspirations of the Palestinian people are essential steps toward realizing their dream of establishing an independent Palestinian state.

China's vested interest lies in witnessing a peaceful and prosperous Middle East. With its expanding economy and trade relationships, China has become a vital partner to countries in the region. China's Belt and Road Initiative spans the Middle East and seeks to contribute to much-needed infrastructure development that will benefit participating countries, including China itself, in the long run.

China has said that it does not intend to change the existing international order, nor to challenge or displace the United States. Instead, China aims to foster development, including complementing domestic and international development programs throughout the Middle East. At a time when the West is experiencing fatigue with Middle East affairs, China's substantial investments, trade, and aid provide public goods that foster development and stability in the Middle East.

In the aftermath of prolonged turmoil in the region, a developmental approach to peace-building is worth exploring. Addressing the root causes of regional insecurity, such as economic stagnation, high unemployment, inadequate infrastructure, rapid population growth, and brain drain, should take precedence over exporting governance models. Expanding mutually beneficial trade and investment, facilitating economic assistance, and prioritizing sustainable development are paramount for achieving long-lasting peace in the Middle East.

China Can Help Trump and Putin End the War in Ukraine⁷

The continuing war in Ukraine has proven that Russia finds it difficult to work with European- or American-led negotiation teams, but China may be able to serve in a facilitating role that could help secure peace.

US President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin's upcoming summit in Alaska this Friday represents a hopeful start to ending the war in Ukraine. But true peace will require more than just the involvement of the United States and Russia. It also requires Ukraine, Europe, the United Nations, and China.

Moscow and Kyiv remain far apart on how to end the war. Despite having suffered staggering casualties with few dramatic changes on the ground, neither side has shown any public willingness to compromise on its key demands. Ukraine is unwilling to accept terms that demand disarmament or the cessation of territory without securing some meaningful protection in return. Russia, of course, is still pushing for these concessions, while rejecting the possibility of a security commitment to Ukraine from NATO.

Yet behind the public posturing, a different reality is taking shape. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has signaled an openness to a resolution with Russia under the right conditions. Putin's regime, in turn, has conveyed its willingness to consider a UN-led peace framework, as shown by statements by Russian UN Ambassador Vassily Nebenzia. In this context, negotiating a solution that respects both sides' red lines is difficult but not impossible.

China is uniquely positioned to help break the gridlock. Beijing can convene a follow-on summit bringing together Ukraine, Russia, the United States, and Europe, leading to a face-to-face meeting among the leaders of all these players. The goal would be to create a formal seven-party talks framework consisting of the five permanent members of the UN Security Council, plus Ukraine and representatives from the European Union.

China has both the diplomatic standing and economic leverage to pull this off. It remains both Russia's and Ukraine's largest trading partner, at \$240.1 billion and \$12.8 billion, respectively, in 2023. Both Russia and Ukraine are members of the Belt and Road Initiative, and China is particularly invested in the stability of Ukraine's grain exports. As a result, Beijing can offer Russia the offramp it needs and provide reconstruction and recovery assistance to Ukraine.

A seven-party talks framework avoids forcing one side to capitulate to the other's narrative. Instead, it works to reframe the problem by seeking out shared interests—such as nuclear safety, regional stability, and an end to the human misery created by active fighting—that can be de-linked from more contentious zero-sum debates.

The first step is a ceasefire. History shows that even partial success here could stop escalation, reintroduce flexibility, and help create a framework within which more lasting arrangements can eventually take shape. The summits and early work need not resolve every territorial or legal claim up front. Instead, they should seek to

⁷ First published on August 13, 2025 by *Foreign Policy* and revised for this collection.

freeze hostilities, open humanitarian corridors, restore basic economic functionality, and begin negotiations on a longer-term settlement.

Once even a limited ceasefire is secured, space would be open for a UN peacekeeping force to expand on it. US Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has stated in NATO meetings in Brussels and at the Munich Security Conference that deploying US forces to Ukraine would be unacceptable and that “any security guarantee must be backed by capable European and non-European troops.”

Hegseth's comments offer a promising way forward. An effective peacekeeping force could be composed of a mixture of non-aligned states and European ones. This would offer a politically viable middle ground, allaying fears on both sides of the conflict. Their physical presence would inhibit future conflict and ensure the beginning of a reconstruction process. Such a force could be composed of five European countries—such as Germany, France, the United Kingdom, Poland, and Italy—and five BRICS nations such as China, Brazil, India, South Africa, and Egypt. This arrangement would underscore neutrality and also distribute responsibility, thereby ensuring broad-based legitimacy and a durable security guarantee.

The BRICS countries' relative distance from European security affairs can be turned into an advantage. Because they are less historically entangled, they are more capable of offering creative guarantees and confidence-building measures that all parties can accept. These should include not only peacekeeping support but also long-term development assistance.

Plans for post-war recovery will be vital. The task of rebuilding Ukraine requires sustained international effort—not only financial, but also logistical and technical. BRICS countries, especially China, have the engineering expertise and financing capacity to aid in reconstruction. China's participation would not only help accelerate Ukraine's recovery but also demonstrate Beijing's wider commitment to peace, stability, and inclusive development. Within this framework, smaller working groups could tackle specific challenges: humanitarian access, territorial disputes, energy infrastructure, and long-term security guarantees—each reinforced by a more diverse coalition of contributors.

A peace summit that includes all stakeholders—perhaps announced at the UN—could demonstrate that competition need not preclude cooperation. As new conflicts from the Middle East to East Asia threaten to multiply, the entire world has a responsibility to help preserve peace. By hosting seven-party talks, Beijing can help lead the way.

Why China Remains the World's Best Chance for Peace in Ukraine⁸

Despite consistent rhetoric surrounding a suspected China-Russia axis, the impasse between Russia and the West means that China with its diplomatic access and record of engagement with all parties, could be the best positioned to bring peace to Ukraine.

The International Organisation for Mediation, an institution designed to supplement and actualize Article 33 of the United Nations Charter, was launched in Hong Kong late last month. Including 32 countries as founding signatories, the organization represents what the world increasingly needs as Russia's invasion of Ukraine drags into its fourth year.

Recent peace talks in Istanbul produced no substantial progress, while blows on the battlefield have long since given way to a grinding impasse. Neither side appears capable of achieving peace, much less victory on the battlefield. Meanwhile, sanctions, weapons deliveries, and rhetorical escalation continue to exacerbate global fragmentation.

Both parties remain deeply divided. US-led efforts to push the two into accepting a ceasefire have so far failed, and it is little wonder why, given the challenges remaining. However, peace could still be in reach if the thorniest issues are addressed. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has expressed his openness to direct negotiations with Russian President Vladimir Putin. At the same time, Russia's ambassador to the United Nations Vassily Nebenzia has reiterated Moscow's willingness to support a UN-led peace initiative for Ukraine, suggesting there is at least an opening.

NATO does not hold the answer, and neither does the presence of US troops. US Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has made it clear that deploying US forces in Ukraine in a peacekeeping role is unacceptable. "...any security guarantee must be backed by capable European and non-European troops," he told a gathering of transatlantic alliance members in Brussels.

Russia is unwilling to accept a peace deal where NATO divisions would be stationed on its border. Similarly, Ukraine cannot accept a peace on Russia's terms that would see it disarmed and geopolitically isolated. A mixture of European and non-European peacekeepers will be vital in allaying the anxieties that have prolonged the conflict.

The situation calls for a force that is militarily capable and politically neutral, one that can be made up of actors with no stake in the conflict. It is in this context that China can offer a solution that warring parties in Europe cannot—a credible alternative grounded in neutrality and mutual respect instead of ideology and alliance politics.

China is the largest contributor of peacekeeping troops among the five permanent members of the UN Security Council. Its forces have served across Africa and the Middle East, from Lebanon to Mali. And unlike many NATO and European

⁸ First published on June 12, 2025 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

nations, China retains diplomatic access and trading relationships with both Kyiv and Moscow.

This is more than a theoretical discussion. Foreign Minister Wang Yi and Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha met on the sidelines of the Munich Security Conference in February. During their talk, Wang emphasized China's commitment to peace through a negotiated resolution. He also highlighted China's role as Ukraine's largest trading partner and a leading importer of Ukrainian agricultural goods.

Meanwhile, China's bilateral trade with Russia reached US\$244.8 billion in 2024, making it Russia's top trading partner. China's simultaneous economic engagement with both warring states makes it one of the few actors with sufficient leverage to bring both to the table. Its links with Russia give it quiet influence, while its openness with Ukraine gives it credibility.

China's refusal to condemn Russia's invasion of Ukraine has been cited as a reason to question its neutrality, but in reality, neutrality is reflected in diplomatic behavior and consistency, not sound bites. China has not provided arms to either side, and while it has not joined the West in imposing sanctions on Russia, nor has it shielded Moscow from the consequences of its actions.

Beijing has stayed engaged with both sides when others have walked away. It has even issued two separate peace proposals. As early as 2022, President Xi Jinping spoke against attempts at nuclear coercion, leading to a 12-point peace proposal on February 24, 2023, the anniversary of the Russian invasion. China and Brazil followed up last year with a six-point joint statement, proposing an international peace conference with equal participation and support from neutral actors.

Western observers have dismissed China's initiatives as vague and driven by self-interest. Yet China's connections to Russia and Ukraine mean there is no country better placed to mediate. Beijing wants to make diplomacy possible, not dictate terms.

Unfortunately, much of Western debate remains framed by talk of a China-Russia axis, which has distorted perceptions and narrowed options. This narrative ignores China's enduring ties with Ukraine and misreads Beijing's intentions. China's strategic interest is in promoting regional stability and preventing economic fallout. It does not benefit from a prolonged war that disrupts supply chains, raises global inflation, and hardens bloc rivalries.

China's regional weight and open diplomatic channels give it a unique opportunity to act quietly but decisively. None of this will be easy. Peace in Ukraine will require difficult compromise and international coordination, and this will not come via escalation or exclusion. A new pathway—one that both involves old actors and brings in new ones, in particular China and the Global South—must be created to restore order through dialogue, balance, and quiet diplomacy.

Ukraine deserves a peace that lasts, and the world deserves a process that works. With its diplomatic access and track record of engagement with all parties, China could be the decisive last mile required to bring about peace in our time.

As we celebrate the 80th anniversary of the UN this year, let us renew our commitment to peace and mediation. We must take this opportunity to break the impasse.

Why China Is Best Placed to Help Negotiate an End to the Ukraine War⁹

Regional links and the apparent weight China seems to carry with Russia could give China formidable influence in pushing forward peace in Ukraine thanks to its open channels of communication with both Kyiv and Moscow.

Last week, many eyes were trained on the ancient city of Samarkand for the annual meeting of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO). Coming at a time of mounting global challenges and geopolitical tensions, the summit showed the importance of the SCO and China's role in promoting multilateralism, connectivity, and development in Central Asia and beyond.

In Samarkand, SCO members adopted more than 40 outcome documents covering a range of fields and issued statements on pressing issues such as food security, energy security, climate change, and supply chain security. New infrastructure projects were also announced, including the Mongolian section of a new Russia-China gas pipeline and a joint agreement between China, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan to build a transnational railroad.

Once complete, it will shorten the rail freight journey from China to Europe, which currently goes through Russia, by 900 km. This new route through Central Asia had long been considered but previously did not proceed, partly because it went against Russia's strategic and economic interests.

The fact that it is now going ahead reflects shifting power dynamics in the region and the evolving China-Russia relationship. These changes were also seen in the meeting between the leaders of the two countries.

On the one hand, China and Russia underscored the strength of the bilateral relationship and pledged to support each other on issues concerning their respective core interests. Russian President Vladimir Putin described the strategic partnership between China and Russia as "solid as a mountain."

In the last few months, a series of events have drawn China and Russia closer together. China was already Russia's biggest trading partner and has become even more economically important for Moscow amid Western sanctions. In the first eight months of this year, total goods trade between China and Russia jumped 31.4% year on year to US\$117.2 billion.

In Samarkand, Putin expressed strong support for China, going so far as to condemn the "provocative moves by individual countries on issues concerning China's core interests." Ongoing developments, such as the progression of the Taiwan Policy Act through the US Congress, are likely to further cement China-Russia alignment on this issue.

On the other hand, in contrast to their unified stance on Taiwan, perhaps the most notable outcome of the meeting was to put clear water between Beijing and Moscow regarding the war in Ukraine. Putin acknowledged the "balanced position"

⁹ First published on September 23, 2022 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

and “questions and concerns” of China on the Ukraine crisis and said he would “explain our position.”

Coming from a leader not known for feeling a need to explain anything to anyone, Putin's admission of Beijing's reservations signals that, contrary to the views of some people, China is not fully aligned with Putin on Ukraine and did not conspire to support the invasion. Putting these statements together, we see that while the bilateral relationship remains strong, China has put some distance between itself and Russia on the Ukraine issue.

Since the start of the war, China has tried to calibrate its actions to remain above the fray. It has not condemned Russia's invasion but has also avoided running afoul of Western-led sanctions against Russia. China also maintains close relations with Ukraine, and in August Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy again urged Beijing to help end the war.

China's balancing act has put it in a position of having the necessary degree of influence and impartiality to help mediate a way out of this crisis. This could involve China and the United Nations taking on a mediating role to facilitate seven-party talks between the five permanent members of the UN Security Council, Ukraine, and the European Union to broker a ceasefire and launch a peace process to end the war.

Some people might find the idea of giving Putin a way out through negotiation unpalatable, especially after breakthroughs by Ukrainian forces have raised the prospect that Ukraine might prevail. But the reality is that there are only four possible outcomes of the war from this point, and none of them are pretty.

First, Russia could lose and be forced to effect a complete withdrawal. However, mounting pressure on Putin could make the situation more dangerous as Russia's leader feels pushed to take increasingly extreme measures—as indicated by the recent escalation of attacks on Ukraine's civilian infrastructure and his ominous warning on Friday that the war could yet “get more serious.”

Second, Russian forces could regroup and eventually defeat Ukraine, forcing Kyiv accept all of Moscow's terms. However, a third, more likely outcome is a grinding and protracted conflict in which neither side prevails, both suffer heavy casualties, and the rest of the world continues to suffer from economic instability and shortages of food and energy.

This leaves the fourth possible outcome and the only real way to stop the bloodshed: a negotiated settlement. That might seem a distant prospect amid the current hostilities and defiant posture of both sides. But the grain export deal brokered by Russia, Ukraine, Türkiye, and the UN in Istanbul on July 22nd shows that intermediaries can play a constructive role.

Like Türkiye, China is one of the few countries to have open dialogue channels with both Kyiv and Moscow, and it has much more influence. Achieving a multilateral resolution to the ongoing War will be a huge challenge, but the SCO summit underscored the fact that there is no country better placed to help achieve this than China.

It's Time to Offer Russia an Offramp, China Can Help with That¹⁰

Russia's miscalculations at the start of the Russia-Ukraine war have put it in an awkward position. Perhaps a China mediated off ramp would be in the interests of all.

Vladimir Putin seems to have assumed he could get a swift victory, underestimating the fierce resistance from Ukraine. Two weeks in, Russia is intensifying its assault on Ukraine, and Western nations in turn are intensifying their financial and economic punishments against Russia, including by triggering the financial “nuclear option”—banning Russian banks from the SWIFT payment system. Meanwhile, Mr. Putin has put his actual nuclear forces on high alert.

We are now in an escalatory spiral. Mounting pressure on Mr. Putin will likely make the situation more dangerous as Russia's leader feels pushed to take increasingly extreme measures—such as what we've seen in the past few days with the Russian army's siege tactics and attacks on civilian areas.

And so, unpalatable as some in the West may find the idea, it is time to offer the Russian leader an offramp with China's help. On Tuesday, President Xi Jinping of China held a virtual summit with President Emmanuel Macron of France and Chancellor Olaf Scholz of Germany, urging a diplomatic solution.

The United States and its allies might be reluctant to have China play any role in this crisis, given that they view Beijing as a strategic rival. That's foolish and short-sighted; the conflict's immediate dangers far outweigh any competitive considerations. Ukraine itself sees the potential of Chinese-led conflict resolution. So far, China has called for dialogue and says it supports humanitarian aid efforts. But Beijing's interests in more proactive involvement are growing by the day.

China has a significant economic interest in a quick resolution to the Russian-Ukrainian war. China enjoys strong ties with Russia and Ukraine and is both countries' largest single trading partner, though each trades more with the EU bloc than with China. Russia and Ukraine are crucial components of the Belt and Road infrastructure program as well as conduits for China's trade with Europe. China-Europe rail transports have experienced a 100-fold increase since the beginning of the 2010s, but the ongoing war threatens to disrupt these trade flows.

China is also uniquely positioned to act as a neutral mediator between a Western-supported Ukraine and Russia. Yes, Beijing and Moscow have a strong and growing relationship, especially in the economic realm. China's demand for resources that Russia has in abundance—food and energy—as well as a mutual dissatisfaction with the current state of the US-led world order have increasingly drawn the two countries together. This alliance was cemented when Mr. Putin and Mr. Xi met last month and issued a joint statement underscoring their deep ties and reaffirming a partnership with “no forbidden zones.”

¹⁰ First published on March 13, 2022 by *The New York Times* and revised for this collection.

It is not in Beijing's interests to rely solely on an anti-Western alliance with Moscow. Russia may possess a mighty military, but its economy is in long-term structural decline, with a GDP not much larger than that of Spain. For all the talk of ties with Moscow, it is worth remembering that China's economic interests with Russia are dwarfed by those it shares with the West. In 2021, trade between China and Russia may have jumped by 36% compared to the prior year, to \$147 billion—but that's still less than a tenth of the combined trade with the United States (\$657 billion) and European Union (\$828 billion).

Even if China isn't joining in the sanctions, it is possible that Chinese businesses and banks will decrease involvement with Russia to avoid a backlash in other, more important markets. As Russia becomes isolated from the world economy, China will not want to shoulder Russia's economic burden alone.

The prospect of a growing economic relationship between Moscow and Beijing may be threatening to the West, but from Mr. Putin's perspective, it provides China with leverage over him in potential negotiations. As he and his country face increasing isolation, he can't afford to lose China, too.

There are also political reasons China wants this war to end in a way that is appealing to all involved. The longer the war lasts, the more it will reinvigorate the Western alliance around the idea of a values-based confrontation between East and West, bringing the United States and the European Union into even closer alignment while driving military budgets up around the globe. That is not good for China, which would prefer to maintain lucrative economic ties with the West and focus its resources on domestic development.

At a time when China faces increasing global criticism for its human rights violations, mediating an end to this war could help improve the country's standing with the West. Beijing has long striven to convince political and business elites in Europe and America that the rise of China does not present a threat. Support for Russian aggression—even perceived support—threatens to undermine that assertion. By contrast, playing a constructive role in ending the war could help cast China as a strategic and not just economic partner.

Ideologically, China has common ground with both Ukraine and Russia. China deeply values the principle of state sovereignty and has long opposed outside interference in what it considers internal affairs such as Taiwan. Last month, Foreign Minister Wang Yi of China once again called for a global respect for territorial integrity, saying, "Ukraine is no exception." In this way, at least, Mr. Putin's invasion directly undercuts one of China's key values.

China—like Russia—is wary of pro-democratic Western influence globally. So far, Chinese media has avoided criticism of Russia and even adopted Moscow's narrative of the war. The two countries share grievances over perceived Western hostility and hypocrisy. Framing the invasion as anti-West and anti-NATO helps justify Mr. Putin's action to a domestic audience.

The longer the war goes on, though, China may find itself in a position of diminishing returns in its close relationship with Russia. This makes the argument for Beijing to take on an active mediation role even more compelling.

What form could mediation take? Any serious resolution would have to involve the United States and the European Union as key actors in European security arrangements. Beijing could help to broker an immediate ceasefire as a prelude to talks among Russia, Ukraine, the United States, the European Union and China.

Beijing's goal would be to find a solution that gives Mr. Putin sufficient security assurances that can be presented as a win to his domestic audience while protecting Ukraine's core sovereignty and NATO's open-door policy. Finding a landing zone for such an agreement is challenging but not impossible. Some creative diplomacy could solve this, such as a formula for NATO expansion that rules out Ukrainian membership in practice while preserving its sovereignty and NATO principles in theory.

Securing a multilateral resolution to the crisis in Ukraine will be a tough and risky challenge, but there is no country better placed to do so than China.

As Ukraine War Drags On, Why Not Give China's Peace Plan a Chance?¹¹

Suspicious of Beijing's motives, the West has dismissed its plan as having no actionable solutions. But with leverage over Moscow and skin in the game, there is no other country better placed to mediate.

There are basically two ways that wars end: in an outright victory or with a negotiated settlement. After a year of fighting in Ukraine, there is a growing consensus that neither side can secure a total victory any time soon.

Russia appears to lack the capability to overcome Ukraine while Western support continues. But Russian forces have dug in and it looks increasingly unlikely that Ukraine can eject them, even with better kit from the West.

Russian President Vladimir Putin will not give up—he sees defeat as an existential threat and has the resources to fight a prolonged war of attrition. And there remains the nightmarish possibility he could reach for the nuclear option if backed into a corner.

Meanwhile, sanctions have not crippled the Russian economy, and there is no sign of a serious effort to topple Putin. Any putsch is more likely to come from the ultranationalist right, and unlikely to end the fighting.

The longer the war drags on, the more suffering it causes. Odds are, we will be marking another grim anniversary next year—and who knows how many after that. Countless people will be killed, wounded, or made homeless. Disrupted flows of grain and energy will worsen hunger in vulnerable regions and aggravate global inflation, feeding instability.

If neither side can prevail, the only way the bloodshed can end is at the negotiating table. Granted, that too seems unlikely—but not impossible.

The peace plan issued by China two weeks ago was immediately dismissed by the European Union and the United States—but, importantly, not by Russia or Ukraine. The United Nations called the plan an “important contribution”, and while it is by no means perfect, it is the only option on the table.

With no end to the war in sight, the plan deserves proper consideration—if only as a stepping stone to a ceasefire and seven-party peace talks under the UN, to include the five permanent Security Council members, Ukraine, and the EU.

There are two main criticisms in the West of Beijing's proposal. But neither is sufficient to dismiss it out of hand.

The first is that the paper doesn't offer actionable solutions. Indeed, it is largely a reiteration of principles and leaves crucial issues unaddressed. But it should be taken as a starting point. There is no way China—or any other party—can provide ready-made answers. Specifics must be thrashed out through negotiations between the key players.

The second, more serious objection is that many in the West do not see Beijing as a credible mediator. From the start of the war, Beijing has straddled an awkward

¹¹ First published on March 7, 2022 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

position on Ukraine. Its refusal to condemn Moscow's invasion means many in the West view China's stance as "pro-Russian neutrality."

But it should be recognized that China has been cautious to avoid crossing the line on Western sanctions. China has provided humanitarian support to Ukraine, but there is no evidence it has supplied arms to Russia.

China's refusal to join the campaign against Moscow may not sit well in the West, but it remains the majority stance elsewhere. More importantly, it is precisely this reluctance to intervene that puts Beijing in a unique position to help mediate.

Many are suspicious of Beijing's motives for stepping in now. There is no doubt China has much to gain if it can help broker an end to the war.

International trade has been hit, and China is the biggest trading nation and the largest trading partner of both Russia and Ukraine. Fighting has also disrupted a key corridor of the Belt and Road Initiative and overland trade with Europe, while driving volatility in global markets that hurts China as a major importer of energy and grain.

Strategically, playing mediator will help China enhance its image, especially in the Global South, and preserve its strategic partnership with Russia, while ending a conflict that is damaging relations with the West. Brokering peace may not diminish competition with the United States, but would surely help Beijing repair relations with the EU and peel the bloc away from Washington.

Cynical motivations aside, China remains best placed to mediate—and the only one with significant leverage over Moscow. Beijing's skin in the game only raises the chance of success; mediation does not have to be an act of altruism to work.

US President Joe Biden said the idea of China helping to negotiate a peace is "just not rational." But it seems to me the objection is driven more by emotion and moral outrage.

Beijing's self-interest and failure to take a stance against Russia do not negate the fact that peace would benefit everyone, and let us focus on our other manifold challenges. The West would be cutting off its nose to spite its face if it dismisses a potential path to peace just because it came from China.

Also, if Beijing is serious about brokering peace, it must address the doubts over its willingness and ability to mediate fairly. For example, China's leadership has been in contact with Putin since the crisis began, but has yet to speak to Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. After the plan was released, Zelenskyy said he planned to talk to President Xi Jinping. Making this happen would be a good start.

Securing a multilateral resolution to the crisis in Ukraine is a long shot. China will have to stick its neck out further than it has ever been willing to for there to be any chance of success. But there is no country better placed to do so. The West should give it a chance.

Alarm over a “China-Russia Axis” Revives Unwanted Cold War Mentality¹²

Rumors of a new alliance between China and Russia are counter to both China's interests and actions. China's consistent foreign policy and calls for peace and continued engagement with all parties should serve to dispel lingering Cold War-era paranoia.

Fifty years ago last week, President Nixon made his landmark visit to Beijing that thawed tensions with China and reshaped the geopolitics of the Cold War. After the Sino-Soviet split of the 1960s had effectively turned a bipolar world order into a “tripolarity,” Nixon's trip and the rapprochement it symbolized substantially altered the balance of power in the triangle of Chinese-Soviet-US relations.

The “strategic triangle” was the dominant frame through which geopolitics was understood at the height of the Cold War. It largely fell dormant with the fall of the USSR but has now been revived by some Western observers with Putin's Russia filling in for the Soviet Union.

This revival has been triggered by events in Ukraine and the joint statement between China and Russia on February 4th which was seen by some as a mirror moment of Nixon's 1972 China visit. It has generated a wave of headlines in the US warning of “The New Axis of Autocracy,” an “alliance of autocracies,” and a “New Superpower Struggle amongst US, Russia, and China.”

But whatever the Cold War echoes in the current Ukraine crisis, applying this twentieth-century triangular framing to our world today is a dangerous and misguided anachronism, for three major reasons.

First, it misreads China's relations with Russia and intentions vis-à-vis the West. Ultimately, China wants to stabilize and improve ties with the United States and its allies, not forge an anti-Western alliance with Russia.

The February 4th statement was a commitment to work together on shared interests, not the declaration of a joint anti-Western front that some have made it out to be. China has no alliance with Russia and has never supported a Russian invasion of Ukraine, as made clear again recently by Foreign Minister Wang Yi's call to respect the sovereignty of any country and find a solution to the Ukraine crisis through dialogue and consultation.

For all the budding talk of ties with Moscow, it is worth remembering that China's economic interests with Russia are dwarfed by those it shares with the West. In 2021, bilateral trade between China and Russia jumped by 35% to a value of US\$147 billion. This was still less than a tenth of the combined trade with the United States (US\$657 billion) and the EU (US\$828.1 billion).

Russia may be a big fish militarily, but it is an economic minnow in long-term structural decline, with a GDP barely larger than that of the EU's fifth-largest economy, Spain. It is not in China's interests to open up a long-term confrontation against the West with such a partner, and in Beijing there is no intent to do so.

¹² First published on March 1, 2022 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

The next major flaw with the triangular view is that our world is not tripolar, or indeed bipolar, but multipolar. The Cold War framing leaves out important geopolitical players, not least the EU, which has major interests at stake in Ukraine and is pursuing an increasingly independent foreign policy.

True, the EU has traditionally punched below its weight strategically, and the Ukraine crisis has temporarily reinvigorated the transatlantic alliance. But the EU no longer wishes to be hemmed to the US position and appears to be at the dawn of a new political era in which it will carve out its own global role.

With Angela Merkel gone and Germany's new chancellor, Olaf Scholz, still finding his feet, Emmanuel Macron is set to be the EU's dominant voice for some time to come, provided he wins the upcoming presidential election in April as expected.

The French president is a strong proponent of strategic autonomy for the EU, and has made it clear the EU should not gang up on China with the United States. In a call with President Xi Jinping on February 16th, the leaders pledged that China and the EU will work together on shared interests like trade, the delayed China-EU investment agreement (opposed by the United States), and climate change.

The issue of climate brings us to the third and perhaps the most important reason Cold War framings are an unhelpful way to view power and security in the twenty-first century.

In an age of global threats that cannot be overcome by brute force or any country acting alone, to focus solely on "power over" other countries is to neglect the more important dimension of "power with" other countries to tackle our shared challenges. The need to consider power in both its competitive and cooperative forms should be clear as we continue to face a global pandemic and looming climate emergency.

There is a danger that framing the world as a strategic triangle of competing powers will become a self-fulfilling prophecy and lock us into a zero-sum view of our interests, when in fact the biggest threats we face come not from other states, but from a collective failure to cooperate on our shared challenges.

Fifty years ago, the leaders of China and America were able to put pragmatism over ideology to achieve a diplomatic breakthrough that reshaped the Cold War triangle and served the interests of both countries.

But reviving this outdated view of the world half a century late will only push China and Russia closer together, raising the risk of great power conflict and hampering our ability to work together on existential threats that go far beyond Ukraine.

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